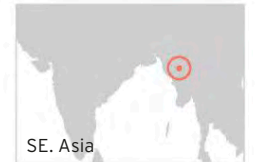


Temples of Bagan

More than 2,200 Buddhist temples and pagodas spread across the plains of the ancient kingdom of Bagan



The kingdom of Bagan, or Pagan, on the plains of the Irrawaddy River in present-day Mandalay, Myanmar (formerly known as Burma), was the principal power in the region from the 9th to the 13th centuries. It established a distinctive Burmese culture, at the center of which was the practice of Theravada Buddhism. During this period, more than 10,000 Buddhist temples were erected on the Bagan plains, and although less than a quarter have survived, the panorama of pagodas rising from the landscape is an extraordinary spectacle.

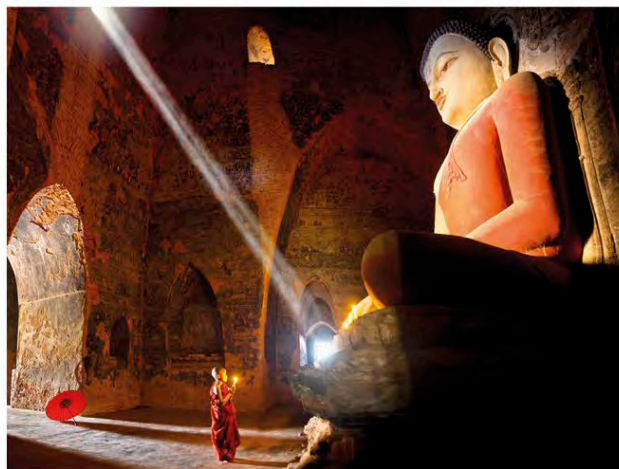
Evolving style

The structures at Bagan provide a unique record of the development of Burmese temple architecture. Some are simple stupas, also known as pagodas—solid hemispherical shrines to contain relics—built in an essentially Indic style; later buildings, comprising

temples topped with pagodas, show a transition to what is now recognized as a distinct Burmese style. Typically, the stupas evolved from a dome-shaped form to a more slender, bell-shaped structure while the temples beneath became more complex places of worship, with spacious, decorated interiors matching the sophistication of the exterior. These buildings generally had either one or four entrances, but a uniquely Bagan style of pentagonal temple also evolved.

Afterlife

Since the fall of the Bagan kingdom in the 13th century, few new temples have been built, and many were ruined by neglect and the effects of earthquakes. Unfortunately, in recent times, several of the remaining temples have been inappropriately restored, but a majority, including some of the finest, have been sensitively maintained.



◁ VISTA OF PAGODAS

The Bagan landscape is punctuated by elegant, conical or bell-shaped pagodas of countless Buddhist temples rising from the plains. Smaller temples are grouped around the more important temples.

△ TEMPLE INTERIOR

Beneath the pagodas, most of the distinctive Burmese temples have spacious interiors decorated with Buddhist artwork and containing statues of the Buddha.

THE HTI

A distinctive feature of almost all the temples in Myanmar is the *hti*, or “umbrella,” a finial ornament on the spires of the pagodas. Typically, these spires are made of increasingly small concentric stone rings, with a *hti* at the tip. *Htis*, in a great variety of designs, are often adorned with bells and hanging decorations, and many are topped with precious stones. The *htis* of the Bagan temples, unlike the metal examples elsewhere in Myanmar, are made of stone plated with gold.

